

BANGLADESH AND NEPAL

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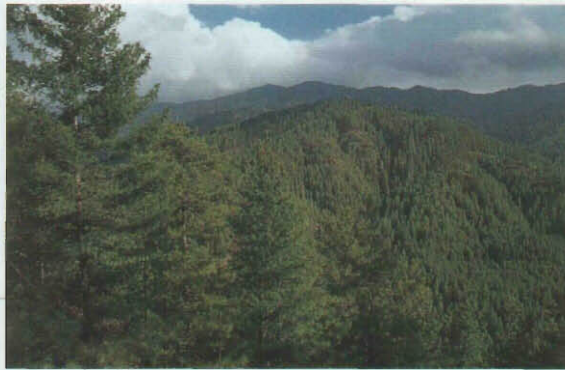


NORTH OF THE BAY OF BENGAL, between India and Burma (Myanmar), is Bangladesh, a poor but fertile country whose low-lying land and repeated flooding has largely dictated its fortunes. Nepal and Bhutan are small

Himalayan states, ruled by kings, but slowly adopting democratic ideas. All three countries have a subsistence farming economy, and the majority of the people, who are a mix of Muslims, Hindus, and Buddhists, live in small, rural villages. Manufacturing industries are being developed.

Physical features

Bangladesh is dominated by a low-lying plain created by soil caught up and carried on the great Ganges River and its tributaries. Much of the land is less than 15 m (50 ft) above sea-level. By contrast, Nepal and Bhutan sit high in the mountains, with plunging forested valleys watered by many rapid streams.



Forests

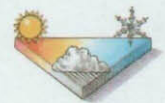
About 70 per cent of Bhutan is forested. Deciduous forests, which include hardwoods such as teak, grow in the south, while thick pine forests cover the steep mountains of central Bhutan. Bangladesh's flat landscape rises in the north and southeast to form wooded hills.



Himalayas

Nepal lies in the highest part of the Himalayas, a vast mountain range that stretches 2,400 km (1,500 miles) between India and China. Mount Everest, the world's highest peak at 8,848 m (29,029 ft), is part of the range and several other peaks are more than 6,000 m (19,685 ft) high, including Ama Dablam in Nepal, at 6,856 m (22,493 ft).

23°C (73°F) 11°C (52°F)



1,901 mm (75 in)

Regional climate

Bangladesh has a hot tropical climate, and monsoon winds bring heavy floods to 67 per cent of the country. Southern Nepal and Bhutan are hot and wet, but the Himalayas are cold and harsh, with much snow.

